User Experience and Accessiblity in Digital Humanities Projects: A Survey

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Introduction

We are interested in understanding how digital humanities (DH) scholars use the user experience (UX) process to build, design, improve, and sustain their digital projects, public archives, and apps. We have noticed a trend wherein some DH labs have established UX teams, often made up of students and academic specialists. However, the majority of DH scholars note that they are without such teams, often having to cobble together the user experience without that level of expertise and support (Warwick, 2012). Knowing how important it is to have a strong user experience to support digital storytelling in the humanities, we are wondering how typical teams and individual practitioners/scholars are conducting user research, testing their interfaces, and deploying their tools to the general public and other academic researchers.

History

While we know that there is an entire area of study in the humanities referred to as experience architecture (XA) (Norman, 2013), as well as well-established programs in the sciences such as human-computer interaction (HCI) and graphical user interface design (GUI) in engineering, the connections between UX and DH are tenuous at best. For example, the majority of DH curriculums at the undergraduate and graduate level do not include courses focused on UX (development, design, information architecture, usability testing, etc.). Programs that do include such courses are at the highest echelon of DH research and education, including King's College London, University of California at Los Angeles, and the University of Victoria. At the same time, UX has been an established, growing, and evolving area of practice since the 1980s with several well-known books used regularly in our curriculums and in industry practice (Casey, 2025; Rosenfeld, Morville, & Arango, 2015; Goodwin, 2009; Gothelf & Seiden, 2021; Buley & Natoli, 2024; Albert, Tullis, & Tedesco, 2010; Baxter, Courage, & Caine, 2015).

Why Do We Need The Study?

Our question is looking at why these courses, practices, and processes are not more widespread in DH. Is it a lack of resources, education, tools, knowledge, application to DH, or some form of resistance to what might seem like a social science approach to DH? As scholars who identify as makers in digital humanities and scholars with a home bases in technical communication and digital writing studies, this situation is rather perplexing and feels like a missed opportunity for DH practitioners and scholars to reach a wider audience through more usable interfaces, tools, and stories.

Aims of the Study

Through our work, we are aiming to open a conversation about how we can make the iterative user experience process more integrated within the DH sensibility, widening our work's appeal and access. This survey presented at the conference is the next step in a longer project that began with a landscape analysis and environmental scan of the spaces and places where DH work gets done. There have been several scholars who have published about similar ideas around the importance of interface design and digital humanities (Gibbs and Owens, 2012; Kemman and Kleppe, 2014; Potts, 2015; Thoden et al, 2017; Warwick, 2012; & Warwick et al., 2008). However, there has been very little produced since asking these questions and calling for a deeper understanding of these practices in our projects. With this survey, we are hoping to learn more, using these findings to then move into interviews with DH practitioners and researchers, presenting our work at future conferences, and, potentially, co-editing a collection that will continue to encourage others to consider the UX process in their projects and processes.

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